Part II. Sociotechnical Foundations

While the technical tools, automation, and practices of SRE are highly visible, their effectiveness relies entirely on the humans who build, operate, and organize around them.[1] This section explores the people, teams, and cultures that make SRE possible, providing a blueprint for building and sustaining a healthy SRE organization.

We begin with Chapter 4, "The Cultural Context of SRE". This chapter emphasizes that organizational culture is the foundation of long-term SRE success. Drawing on research from DORA and the Westrum organizational typology, it explores the elements of a generative, reliability-focused culture—such as psychological safety, blamelessness, and a data-driven mindset. It also provides practical advice on how to foster behaviors that shift organizational culture away from silos and reactive firefighting to a healthier state.

A healthy culture requires the right people. In Chapter 5, "SRE Hiring, Training, and Career Management", we discuss how to attract and retain engineers with the T-shaped blend of broad system knowledge and deep technical expertise required for SRE. The chapter outlines Google's approach to interviewing, the importance of hands-on training programs to build confidence, and how SREs can build long-term careers through continuous learning, initiative, and technical leadership.

With the right people in place, they must be organized effectively. Chapter 6, "Organizational Structures for SRE", examines how lines of management and communication influence a team's success. It discusses navigating the continuum between centralized and decentralized models, the design of individual SRE teams (including the balance of managers, tech leads, and program managers), and how maturity matrices can assess and guide an organization's operational health as it scales.

Finally, Chapter 7, "SRE Engagement Models", details how SRE teams interact with their product development partners. The chapter explores how SRE engagement models have evolved beyond a static, one-size-fits-all approach to operational support, ranging from embedded SREs to tools- and infrastructure-focused teams. It also describes Google's evolution from a depth-first model focused on supporting a handful of services at a time to dynamic, outcome-focused engagements aligned with broader business goals.

Together, these chapters provide the foundational framework for the human elements of SRE, setting the stage for the practical, operational work of building and maintaining resilient systems.

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[1] Ranga Ramanujam and Karlene H. Roberts, *Organizing for Reliability* (Stanford University Press, 2018).

Previous chapter
< 3. Trends in Production

Next chapter
4. The Cultural Context of SRE >